

SIPRA DAS



TRIUMPH: Swaraj with Karat and Congress MP Prabha Thakur

"blind adherent" of the Left view. "We have got all the facts about the deal from the Left. If the government brings out more facts, we will go through them," says Amar Singh.

There are more instances of SP's supping with the Congress. In Karnataka, the Congress has extended support to SP candidate and former chief minister S. Bangarappa in Shikaripura, where he takes on BJP's chief ministerial candidate B.S. Yeddyurappa. While BSP had hit out against Rahul Gandhi when he visited Bundelkhand last month, SP had applauded his "efforts to take up the cause of the common". In spite of SP's public fury, CPI(M) claims that the differences are just "minor hiccups". The events in the coming days will prove how skin-deep the relations are. **by Shafi Rahman**

SP Flashes the Red Card

DELHI They are supposed to be "natural allies"—hand-in-hand on all the issues confronting the nation. The two were also seen as the vanguard of the emerging Third Front in the upcoming general elections. But suddenly, relations between the Left and the Samajwadi Party

(SP)—have taken a free fall. The introduction of the Women's Reservation Bill marked the onset of the summer of discontent for the one-time secular buddies. The bill hit a raw political nerve of the SP whose General Secretary Amar Singh termed it the "Brinda-Sushma Bill". The

SP sees this as an opportunity to cosy up with the Congress. Speculation is rife that the Congress is courting SP chief Mulayam Singh for support on the nuclear deal and a patch-up in Uttar Pradesh in the run-up to the polls.

SP has softened its stand towards the Congress and distanced itself from the Left on the nuke deal saying it is not a

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Here is proof that Women's Reservation Bill tabled in Parliament is just a sham. In the Karnataka assembly elections, major political parties together put up just 17 women candidates, less than 5 per cent of the total.

VOICES



"Whether somebody agrees to it or not, I think the AICC knows that I am not a sycophant."

Arjun Singh, Union minister for human resource development

"My advice to the Congress and the BJP would be to come together and run the country. If this happens, India will be a superpower in no time."

P.A. Sangma, NCP leader

"I am not a kingmaker. I want to be the king."

H.D. Kumaraswamy, JD(S) leader

"Stalin is doing very well as a leader and has been around for 40 years. Azhagiri is not directly in politics, nor is he interested. The difference is more of a media created issue."

Kanimozhi Karunanidhi, DMK MP

"I won't say that coming into politics was a mistake, but yes, an actor should not come into politics as it divides the audience and his general acceptance among fans."

Dharmendra, actor and BJP MP

